LILLE, FRANCE

Palais des Beaux-Arts de Lille: Masterpieces

Twenty pictures in which a raised hand, a turned head or an ordinary pause changes the scale of the subject.



In David's *Belisarius*, a soldier recognises a fallen general while a woman offers help. The gestures make a public history intelligible through a small encounter. Elsewhere in this selection, a crowd lifts Marat above its heads, two women lean together in confidence, and a sleeping girl withdraws from activity altogether.

These scenes do not ask for the same kind of attention. Some announce their subject through a conspicuous action; others require time with an almost uneventful arrangement. Even the landscapes alternate between directed movement and stillness. The guide follows those differences across twenty collection works, leaving their historical reputations in the background long enough to notice what each picture actually gives its figures to do.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/palais-beaux-arts-lille

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16. Pear Pickers
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17. The Old Women, or Time
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18. In the Woods
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19. Erigone
    Gustave Moreau · c. 1865
20. Winter: Snow Effect
    Alfred Sisley · 1876

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Belisarius Begging for Alms

Jacques-Louis David

1781 · Oil on canvas · Palais des Beaux-Arts de Lille



Belisarius Begging for Alms. WikiArt; Jacques-Louis David. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

The helmet no longer protects its wearer; it receives charity. Around this reversal, David assigns distinct actions to the boy, the approaching woman and the astonished soldier. The blind general cannot share their act of recognition. His dependence is made visible through the different kinds of knowledge and assistance held by the people around him.

Object source · Open artwork

02 / 20

Five Studies of Cows

Jacob Jordaens

1624 · Oil on canvas · Palais des Beaux-Arts de Lille



Jacob Jordaens. Five studies of cows. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/jacob-jordaens/five-studies-of-cows-1624 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

These cattle occupy one surface without becoming a single continuous scene. Standing and resting bodies offer Jordaens different problems of weight, overlap and the turn of a head. The repetitions preserve the practical character of a study. A familiar animal must still be observed anew when its position changes; one successful outline cannot do every job.

Object source · Open artwork

03 / 20

The Triumph of Marat

Louis-Léopold Boilly

c. 1794 · Oil on white paper mounted on canvas · Palais des Beaux-Arts de Lille



Louis-Léopold Boilly. Le triomphe de Marat. Image credit: Louis-Léopold Boilly; Own work. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Lille_PBA_boilly_triomphe_de_marat.jpg. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · Public domain

Marat's elevation is literal: the crowd carries him. Raised arms and clustered heads make public importance visible as collective behaviour rather than as a quality inherent in the central body. Boilly gives the surrounding people much of the picture's work. Remove their coordinated attention and the figure above them would lose the conditions of his triumph.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: P 395

04 / 20

Medea

Eugène Delacroix

1838 · Oil on canvas · Palais des Beaux-Arts de Lille



Medea. WikiArt; Eugène Delacroix. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

The close grouping might initially resemble protection: an adult holds two children within a rocky shelter. Medea's turned head and tense grip prevent that arrangement from becoming secure. Knowledge of the myth makes the children's dependence especially troubling. Delacroix concentrates the threat inside bodily contact rather than placing danger at a reassuring distance from the family.

Object source · Open artwork

05 / 20

Robespierre

Louis-Léopold Boilly

c. 1791 · Oil on canvas · Palais des Beaux-Arts de Lille



Louis-Léopold Boilly. Portrait de Maximilien Robespierre. Image credit: Louis-Léopold Boilly; Own work. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Lille_PBA_Boilly_robespierre.jpg. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · Public domain

Papers, a desk and orderly clothing present a composed civilian sitter. It is tempting to search the face for a later political reputation, but the portrait does not supply evidence for that retrospective judgment. Boilly's restrained arrangement is more useful as an account of presentation: the sitter appears through the conventions of a particular kind of formal likeness.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: P 396

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Study for the Race of the Barbary Horses

Théodore Géricault

1817 · Oil on canvas · Palais des Beaux-Arts de Lille



Study for the Race of the Barbarian Horses. WikiArt; Théodore Géricault. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

The horse is being held, not yet released. Géricault concentrates on the unstable interval in which human limbs and the animal's neck pull in competing directions. Closely packed bodies make it difficult to isolate a single action. Restraint becomes visible as continuous effort, and the anticipated race is already present in the forces resisting that effort.

Object source · Open artwork

07 / 20

After the Thaw: The Seine at the Pont de Suresnes

Alfred Sisley

1880 · Oil on canvas · Palais des Beaux-Arts de Lille



Alfred Sisley. APRES LA DEBACLE LA SEINE AU PONT DE SURESNES. Image credit: Alfred Sisley; Own work. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Lille_PdBA_sisley_apres_la_debacle.JPG. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · Public domain

The river occupies an unusually broad, pale area beside the wet bank. Small walkers make its width measurable without taking over the scene. Sisley allows a change in weather to alter the landscape's proportions: water claims space that might otherwise belong to firm ground. The result depends on those changed boundaries more than on an isolated picturesque detail.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: P 1894

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Apelles Painting Campaspe in the Presence of Alexander

Jacques-Louis David

c. 1814 · Oil on wood · Palais des Beaux-Arts de Lille



Jacques-Louis David. Apelle peignant Campaspe en présence d'Alexandre. Image credit: Sailko; Own work. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Jacques-louis_david,_apelle_ritrae_camaspe_alla_presenza_di_alessandro,_1813-23_ca.jpg. CC BY 3.0 (https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/3.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · CC BY 3.0

The easel divides an encounter involving a painter, a model and a ruler. Each occupies a different relation to the image being made. David turns an ancient subject into a painting about access and attention: the model is looked at, the painter works, and the visitor observes. The canvas stands between those activities rather than disappearing behind the story.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: P 444

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Travellers in a Rocky Landscape

David Teniers the Younger

Second half of the 17th century · Oil on canvas · Palais des Beaux-Arts de Lille



David Teniers the Younger. BOHEMIENS. Image credit: David Teniers the Younger; Own work. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Lille_PdBA_tenier_jeune_bohemiens.JPG. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · Public domain

The travellers are small enough to make the rocks formidable. Their route nevertheless introduces a passage through terrain that first appears obstructive. Teniers balances enclosure with a prospect of open country, allowing the eye to alternate between following the path and looking beyond it. The people establish both scale and the possibility of movement.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: P 107

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Bouquet of Flowers

Roelant Savery

c. 1620 · Oil on wood · Palais des Beaux-Arts de Lille



Roelant Savery. BOUQUET DE FLEURS. Image credit: Roelant Savery; Own work. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Lille_PdBA_savery_bouquet_de_fleurs.JPG. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · Public domain

The bouquet's crowded centre does not erase the differences between its flowers. Savery gives individual stems and delicate edges enough contrast against the dark ground to remain legible. Fallen blossoms extend the arrangement beyond the vase. The painting offers a useful distinction between abundance and uniformity: many forms share the space without becoming one indistinct mass.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: P 1036

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Brie-sur-Marne

Stanislas Lépine

c. 1873 · Oil on canvas · Palais des Beaux-Arts de Lille



Stanislas Lépine. BRIE-SUR-MARNE. Image credit: Stanislas Lépine; Own work. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Lille_PdBA_lepine_brie_sur_marne.JPG. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · Public domain

The inhabited bank has a second, less solid existence in the water. Lépine organises river, houses and sky into broad horizontal zones, then allows their reflections to loosen the division. Little appears to happen, but looking between a building and its reflected counterpart produces small changes of shape. Stillness is not the same as exact repetition.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: P 1943

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A Shepherd from the Landes

Rosa Bonheur

Second half of the 19th century · Oil on canvas · Palais des Beaux-Arts de Lille



Rosa Bonheur. Berger Landais. Image credit: Rosa Bonheur; Own work. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Lille_Pdba_bonheur_berger_landais.JPG. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · Public domain

Bonheur brings the shepherd close enough for the rough outer garment to matter alongside the face. The dark cap and blue sky clarify the turned head, while the cropping removes a larger account of rural work. Occupation remains present in clothing and bearing. The worker receives the concentrated attention of a portrait rather than serving as a small landscape accessory.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: P 604

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Pug with a Red Ribbon

Jean-Baptiste Oudry

1730 · Oil on canvas · Palais des Beaux-Arts de Lille



Jean-Baptiste Oudry. CARLIN PARE D'UN RUBAN ROUGE. Image credit: Jean-Baptiste Oudry; Own work. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Lille_PdBA_oudry_carlin.jpg. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · Public domain

The ribbon introduces a bright accent at the neck, but the dog's stance carries the image. Oudry sets the compact pale body against darker surroundings so that its open mouth and alert position remain distinct. An animal portrait need not imitate a human sitter's dignity. Attention to the creature's particular proportions supplies its own terms.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: P 348

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Wheat Field

Jacob van Ruisdael

c. 1660 · Oil on canvas · Palais des Beaux-Arts de Lille



Jacob van Ruisdael. CHAMP DE BLE. Image credit: Jacob van Ruisdael; Own work. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Lille_PdBA_Van_Ruisdael_champ_de_ble.JPG. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · Public domain

The curved path proposes a journey through cultivated ground, while the large cloud banks claim another kind of scale above it. Ruisdael places small travellers between these competing expanses. Their route makes the terrain continuous and traversable, but the sky prevents the fields from feeling wholly controlled by human activity. Cultivation and weather occupy the same view.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: P 224

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Confidence

Jules Breton

1864 · Oil on canvas mounted on wood · Palais des Beaux-Arts de Lille



Jules Breton. Trust. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/jules-breton/trust-1864 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

One young woman leans towards the other, bringing their bodies into a shared direction. Breton makes the relationship readable while withholding the content of the exchange. The surrounding space remains available, yet the pair's closeness marks a smaller private area within it. There is no need to invent their conversation to recognise the intimacy of its arrangement.

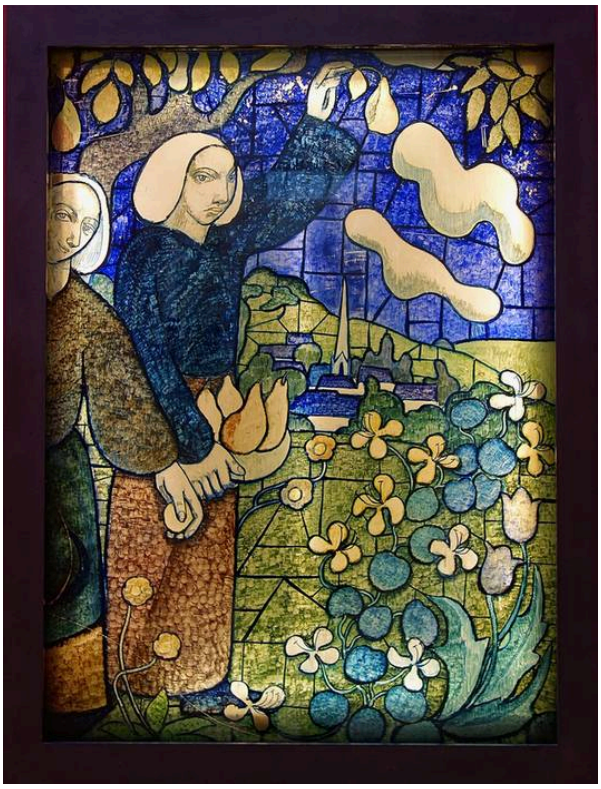
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: P 513

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Pear Pickers

Émile Bernard

1888 · Oil on glass · Palais des Beaux-Arts de Lille



Émile Bernard. CUEILLEUSES DE POIRES. Image credit: Émile Bernard; Self-photographed. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Lille_PdBA_emile_bernard_cueilleuses_de_poires.JPG. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · Public domain

Dark contours give the coloured areas boundaries that do not depend on naturalistic shadow. Bernard keeps figures and trees identifiable while compressing their depth. Each patch has a weight in the surface arrangement as well as a role in describing the scene. Following the outlines makes that double function easier to notice than searching for a single convincing viewpoint.

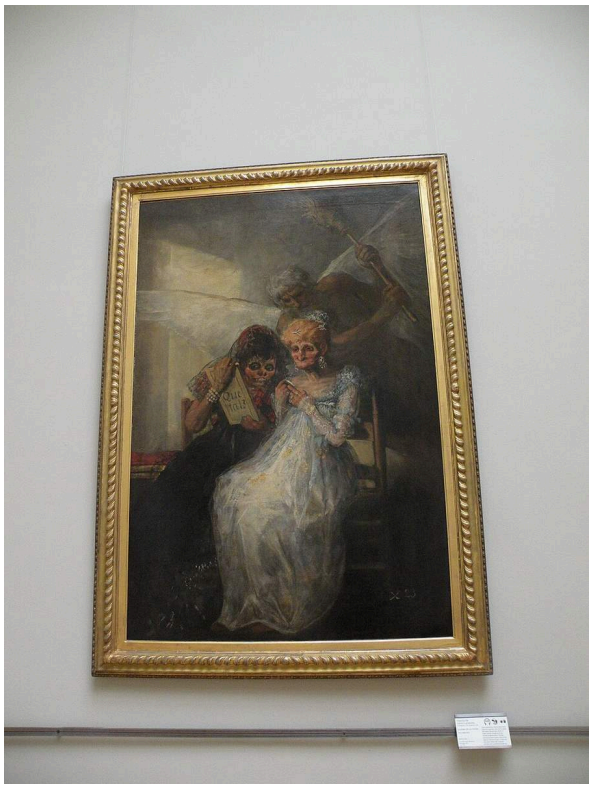
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: P 1822

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The Old Women, or Time

Francisco Goya

c. 1810 · Oil on canvas · Palais des Beaux-Arts de Lille



Francisco Goya. Les vieilles ou Le temps. Image credit: Francisco Goya; Own work , Chatsam , 2015-07-05 11:41:15. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Goya_le_temps_pdba_lille.JPG. CC BY-SA 3.0 (https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/3.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · CC BY-SA 3.0

The mirror offers a small field of self-inspection, while the winged figure and raised broom introduce a larger threat behind the women. Goya does not allow elegant clothing to settle the encounter into a flattering portrait. The picture places the wish to manage appearance beside an image of passing time that appearance cannot control.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: P 50

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In the Woods

Albert Anker

1865 · Oil on canvas · Palais des Beaux-Arts de Lille



Albert Anker. DANS LES BOIS. Image credit: Albert Anker; Joconde database : entry 000PE019295. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Albert_Anker_-_Im_Wald.jpg. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · Public domain

Cut branches locate the sleeping girl near work, but the painting concentrates on its suspension. A hand supports her head as the wooded ground encloses the body. Anker makes an unposed interval available to sustained looking. The scene does not establish a full account of her circumstances; the visible contrast is between signs of activity and present rest.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: P 623

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Erigone

Gustave Moreau

c. 1865 · Oil on wood · Palais des Beaux-Arts de Lille



Gustave Moreau. ERIGONE. Image credit: Gustave Moreau; Own work. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Lille_Pdba_moreau_erigone.JPG. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · Public domain

The pale body emerges from a setting that remains difficult to separate into clear parts. Moreau gives small areas of light the task of distinguishing skin from the dense growth and shadow around it. The mythological name does not immediately clarify the space. Identifying the subject and finding one's way through the picture remain different kinds of reading.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: P 609

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Winter: Snow Effect

Alfred Sisley

1876 · Oil on canvas · Palais des Beaux-Arts de Lille



Alfred Sisley. En hiver effet de neige. Image credit: Patrice78500; Own work. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:En_hiver,_effet_de_neige,_Alfred_Sisley.jpg. CC BY-SA 4.0 (https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/4.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · CC BY-SA 4.0

Snow reduces strong local colours without removing the road's structure. Grey and violet shadows interrupt the white, while converging edges carry carriages and walkers between houses and trees. Sisley gives the soft conditions a definite direction. The scene can remain subdued in colour and still contain a clearly organised pattern of everyday movement.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: P 1895

Leave room for a quiet picture

After the dramatic groups, allow time for Lépine's river or Sisley's snow. The difference in pace is part of this selection. Consult the museum's current information for availability; these works are not promised in a single route or display.

Further reading

Seven Discourses on Art

Joshua Reynolds · Read free · English

Reynolds's Seven Discourses on Art records an influential eighteenth-century argument about the ambitions of painting. It offers a historical counterpoint to the large figure compositions by David and Delacroix, rather than a commentary on these particular works.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12

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